Generations and Do the Math

By Meliza Banales

INTRODUCTION

Meliza Banalez, a Latina slam poet explains: "When the word "diversity" is brought up in Latino circles, it's often a dirty word; in the U.S., it has a history of dismissing us as people or chalking up our collective differences as "other" or "not normal," "normal," of course, being white. For example, I learned growing up, and especially in college, that "diversity" was often seen by most people of color as "teaching the white, normal people to politely deal with the not-so-normal people of color."

In her poems Generations and Do the Math, she graphically depicts what it has meant for her to grow up in the US in a family that struggled to maintain an image that they weren't as poor or as brown or as migrant as they seemed.

Generations

Before men and women were going on strike,

standing on the frontlines with Cesar Chavez screaming,

"Si se puede!"

Yes We Can

my great-grandfather was starting his own revolution,

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teaching himself to read and write by rummaging

through schoolyard trashcans

for used spelling books and old newspapers.

Great-Grandfather came over from Michoacan, Mexico,

to pick cotton in California.

He even helped build the Kansas City Railroad

but ended up being too Mexican

to ride the trains that flew across the tracks of his

hard labor.

And who would have thought

My father, little brown hands picking grapes in the

Fresno heat

would be the first in our family to graduate high school

and end up building satellites for NASA.

And still

you, Mr. Landowner,

can sit

the owner of lives

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and tell me
that we are replaceable.
That somebody's gotta go out there and pick that fruit
because there is a cake that your mother is baking
that needs the perfect sized strawberries.

That we don't deserve more than a fifteen-minute break
a day because
money doesn't grow on trees,
money
doesn't grow
on trees.

Well neither does blood.
Neither do brown hands.
Neither does strength, neither does courage, neither do
weaknesses.

You ask me,
the third generation of the brown blood gone white
if I am ashamed of this heritage and I can tell you

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Senor,
I don't hear shame calling me in my sleep.
I don't hear shame in 3 AM phone calls to my father,
"Papi, I'm working three jobs and I just can't take it
anymore."
"Papi I get down on my knees every day not to pray to
God
but to clean up after people's shit, and I just can't take
it anymore."
"Papi, I'm not gonna make my rent again next month
and I am livin' just enough for the city,
and I just can't take it anymore."

I don't hear shame when my father tells me,
"Mija, haven't you learned by now that there are fields
of soldados,
soldiers swimming through your veins."
"Mija, there are fields of reasons
why the universe only gives you as much as you can
carry."
"Mija,

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there are fields of things that your heart already
knows."
And this I know:
I have crawled across the backs of men and women
just so I could climb back into the womb of a mother
country
so that I could be reborn and say to you,
You do not plant these seeds.
You do not own these roots.
Your government does not birth this fruit.

So don't tell me
how I don't understand the taste of the sweetest red
grapes
on a sunny August morning because trust me
They are filled
with the blood and sweat of three generations of Aztec
warriors.
And I've come to know what the truth
tastes like.

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Do the Math

The equation goes something like this:
one white mother plus one brown father divided by two
different worlds
equals a daughter.
Give or take a decimal the American dream turns out to
be:
two half-white children, two full-brown children,
one small house in LA,
four jobs divided by two high school educated parents
The quality of life is high though the means is low.

The numbers vary from memory to memory. Like three.
Three times a week I clean houses in rich neighborhoods
to
make my way.
Folding sheets is difficult. Every house has one rich
white lady with two dozen sheets
times four beds which equals ten ways to fold the
sheets so that they're
perfect.

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Learning to fold sheets at least three to six ways
means I can clean three to six houses a week
which equals rent, tortillas, and lettuce for the month.

Going into one.
One night a week I go-go dance in a cage in a Hollywood nightclub.
Ten dollars an hour plus tips.
I'm only eighteen back then and already I know the equation for lust:
One bare ass in face gets a twenty, one crotch-drop earns a fifty,
one tongue licking cage bars while slowly gyrating hips
equals I am the first in my family to go to college.

Then there's five.
Five times a day I prayed through my seven-year-old body
that my father would lose his Spanish accent.
I was convinced that if he did he could get a better job

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and we
wouldn't be poor anymore.
I was convinced he just wasn't trying hard enough to say "signals" instead of "singles" or "video" instead of "bideo."

Five times a day I sent my other prayers, my secret prayers
that I was thankful for looking the most white in a family of coffee-colored children.
How I prayed that my brown blood wouldn't seep through my white skin
so that I could
learn English, get an education
make my parents proud of half-white, half-brown accomplishment.

Five times a day times seven days a week plus two small hands clenched together in
fear and ignorance
equals a lifetime of trying to make halves a whole.

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You see, it's all in the numbers.

These numbers that haunt my dreams, make my past into single digits
which have no common denominator.

Just once I'd like to write an equation for all the things I could never write about.

For the three times my father took off work from three different jobs to see me in the
school play.
For the first and last time my sister told her abusive ex-husband that she didn't need
him anymore
and meant it.
For the hundreds of times I saw my parents laugh
until the tears rolled down their cheeks,
even in a neighborhood of drugs and gangs.

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For that one moment,
I did see my father cry
when I, the first in my family, received my college degree.

I'm writing a formula for all the numbers that have fallen on me.

Fifteen sunrises in three different states,
eight million breaths in one kiss,
185 poems in eight years –

I am writing an equation.
Using the universal language of numbers to describe ten thousand ways
that something can mean everything.

It's just all in how you do the math.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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